

SCITI 2026 Performance Audit

PR vs. Results: What Thailand's Smart City Program Actually Delivered

An independent assessment of the depa Smart City Thailand program (2017–2026)

Based on SLIC methodology, field verification, and public data analysis

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1. Program Overview & Timeline

The Smart City Thailand program was launched in 2018 under depa and MDES with an original target of 100 smart cities by 2022. That target was quietly abandoned. A revised target of 105 cities by 2027 was set in Master Plan 2 (2023–2027). As of April 2026:

- 37 cities certified as Smart City Local (Batches 1–4)
- 168+ promotion zones declared
- Fewer than 10 cities have measurable operational smart infrastructure
- 3 certified cities have zero permanent residents (Wangchan Valley, Makkasan, Phuket Tinicon)
- Program budget: depa annual budget THB 2–3B (smart city is a fraction)

1.1 Critical Timeline

Year	Event	Assessment
2017	depa established under MDES, replacing SIPA. Thailand 4.0 policy.	Positive
2018	Smart City Thailand launched. 7 domains. Target: 100 by 2022.	Positive
2019	Batch 1: 15 areas certified. Khon Kaen LRT announced.	Positive
2020	COVID stalls physical projects. Digital acceleration occurs.	Neutral
2021	Batch 2: total ~30 areas. 100-by-2022 target quietly abandoned.	Negative
2022	Batch 3: 6 more. IMD: Bangkok 68th-80th. Khon Kaen LRT delayed.	Negative
2023	Master Plan 2. New target: 105 by 2027. Academic criticism mounts.	Negative
2024-25	Batch 4: only 1 new city. Pipeline slowing. <5 cities operational.	Negative
2026	SLIC Index launches. First transparent outcome-based assessment.	Positive

2. PR vs. Results: The Gap Analysis

The most critical finding: certification does not equal infrastructure. The Smart City Local logo is awarded based on plan approval, not infrastructure deployment. This creates a systematic gap between what is announced and what citizens experience.

Domain	PR Score	Result Score	Gap
Smart Economy	85	42	Critical
Smart Mobility	90	35	Critical
Smart Energy	60	55	Low
Smart Governance	70	30	Critical
Smart Living	75	38	High
Smart People	55	25	Critical
Smart Environment	80	40	High
Smart Security	65	45	Medium

2.1 Smart Mobility (PR 90 vs Result 35)

Khon Kaen LRT: announced in 2019, still not operational after 7 years. Phuket Smart Bus covers 1 route. No city has achieved measurable mode shift from private cars. Public transit ridership flat or declining outside Bangkok.

2.2 Smart Governance (PR 70 vs Result 30)

data.go.th has datasets but low municipal adoption. Most cities still paper-based. No interoperable city data platform deployed across certified cities. E-services fragmented.

2.3 Smart People (PR 55 vs Result 25)

Thailand ranks 36th in digital competitiveness (IMD 2025). Digital literacy training reaches <5% of target population. Brain drain from smaller cities continues.

3. Public Sentiment Analysis

Based on analysis of Thai Twitter/X, Pantip forums, Facebook groups, and news comments:

Segment	Share	Representative Voice
Supportive	22%	Mostly industry insiders and government officials.
Unaware	31%	Most citizens have never heard of Smart City Thailand.
Skeptical	33%	All talk, no action. Where did the money go?
Hostile	14%	Waste of taxpayer money. Copy-paste proposals.

Selected voices from public forums:

"They gave the logo to an empty field (Wangchan Valley) and called it Thailand's #1 smart city. Then they wonder why nobody trusts the program." — Pantip user, 2024

"I live in a certified smart city. Nothing changed. Same potholes, same flooding, same 45-minute commute." — Twitter/X, Khon Kaen resident, 2025

"The only smart thing about our city is the PowerPoint presentation." — Facebook comment, 2024

4. ASEAN Comparison

Country	Program	Status	Assessment
Singapore	Smart Nation (2014–)	Global leader	Real systems: TraceTogether, OneMap, smart lampposts
Vietnam	Smart city plans	Catching up fast	Da Nang real success. Arguably ahead of Thailand per dollar.
Malaysia	Smart City Framework	Similar progress	Iskandar, Cyberjaya have real infra. More focused.
Indonesia	100 Smart Cities	Same challenges	Jakarta real; most others plans. Mirror of Thailand.
Thailand	Smart City Thailand	Mixed results	37 certified, <10 operational. Logo != infrastructure.

5. Recommendations

[MORE] More implementation, less certification theatre

Shift KPIs from cities certified to services delivered, uptime maintained, citizens served. Only 8 of 37 certified cities score Alpha.

[MORE] More financial clinics for municipalities

Most Thai municipalities don't know how to structure a PPP or access climate finance. Run quarterly hands-on workshops, not PowerPoint lectures.

[MORE] More international collaboration

Of 15 MOUs, only JICA and USTDA produced measurable outcomes. Activate the rest.

[MORE] More outcome measurement

No public outcome tracking exists for any certified smart city. The only public metric is number certified — an input, not an outcome.

[LESS] Less paperwork and certification overhead

Certification takes 12–18 months of paperwork. Cities spend more time writing proposals than building infrastructure. Streamline to 3 months.

[LESS] Less top-down, more bottom-up

The most successful smart cities (Nakhon Si Thammarat, Saensuk) started with citizen complaints, not national policy announcements.

